# Preface and Acknowledgements

On 23 March 1906, under the rubric ‘Tuticorin Notes’, a brief notice appeared in *The Hindu*. ‘Swadesism is making rapid strides of progress in Tuticorin,’ it said, adding that ‘the credit is due to Mr V.O. Chidambaram Pillai, prominent pleader and a good Tamil scholar.’

Few would have imagined what the rapid strides would come to mean. It included nothing less than the launch of an indigenous shipping company that took on the might of the British India Steam Navigation Company (BI). The Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company (SSNCo) marked the high point of the Swadeshi movement in south India, and garnered all-India attention. Leading to intense competition, it not only alarmed the global shipping giant but the British Empire as well. Working hand in glove with each other, British businessmen and the colonial state crushed the fledgling company, triggering street fights and state repression. Following a popular protest, four were shot dead, over a hundred convicted, and a huge punitive police force was stationed in Tirunelveli and Tuticorin. If on the Indian side V.O. Chidambaram Pillai (VOC, 1872–1936) was sentenced to double life imprisonment for helming the Swadeshi shipping company, on the British side it led to the murder of a district collector and magistrate, the only political assassination in the Tamil country during the freedom struggle.

For launching an ambitious shipping company to take on the British might, VOC is celebrated in the Tamil region as ‘Kappalottiya Tamilan’—The Tamil Helmsman. Myth, misconception and misinformation abound in the familiar story of SSNCo, however. It is a saga with many twists and turns—and a tragic ending. This book, based on extensive research into various hitherto untapped sources, reconstructs this story in detail for the first time.